

ORIGINS

4.5 MYA–3000 BCE

4.5 MYA		1 MYA		30,000 YA		10,000 BCE	
Olduvai Gorge ▶ c. 4.5 MYA Emergence of an early ancestor of modern humans, <i>Ardipithecus ramidus</i>, in Ethiopia.		c. 1 MYA <i>Homo erectus</i> well established in North Africa and Middle East. c. 600,000 YA <i>Homo heidelbergensis</i> flourishes in Central Europe; introduces Acheulean stone tools (carefully flaked on both surfaces).		c. 150,000 YA Emergence of first <i>Homo sapiens</i>, Africa; subsequently coexists with <i>Homo erectus</i> in Asia and <i>Homo neanderthalensis</i> (Neanderthals) in Europe and Middle East.		c. 10,000 BCE Rising temperatures, retreating ice sheets, rising sea levels. Siberia separated from North America, continental shelves flooded.	
◀ "Lucy" skeleton c. 3 MYA <i>Australopithecus afarensis</i>, known as "Lucy," lives in East Africa. c. 2.5 mya First genus of human, <i>Homo habilis</i>, Olduvai Gorge, East Africa.		▼ Neanderthal skull		▲ Ice age landscape c. 30,000 ya Cro-Magnon cave art and decorated artifacts in Western and Central Europe.		▼ Domesticated goats	
c. 2.75–1 MYA Earliest known stone tools found, Ethiopia. Meat now apparently a central part of energy-rich diet of hominins. c. 1.8 MYA–500,000 YA Evidence of deliberate use of fire.		▲ <i>Homo sapiens</i> skull c. 70,000 YA Population spread halted, possibly due to catastrophic volcanic eruption of Toba, Sumatra; global temperatures lowered for a millennium.		c. 24,000 YA Disappearance of <i>Homo neanderthalensis</i>.		◀ Village settlement c. 10,000 BCE First settled agriculture in Anatolia (Turkey), Middle East, and Mesopotamia. Evidence of early sheep and goat domestication in northern Mesopotamia.	
▲ Fire c. 4.2 MYA Earliest of the australopithecines ("southern ape-humans"), East Africa; walks on two feet, has a brain one-third the size of modern humans.		c. 350,000 YA <i>Homo neanderthalensis</i> emerges in Europe.		c. 20,000 YA Ice Age populations live by hunting and gathering, building shelters from available resources.		▼ Hunter-gatherers	
Acheulean hand-ax ▶		c. 10,000 BCE Earliest pottery from Jomon, Japan, heralds gradual revolution in transportation and storage of food.		Jomon pottery ▶			